the Trump administration sought greater autonomy to craft US trade policy, particularly as it ramped up its trade war with China. Trump's preference for bilateral trade deals, which would maximize US leverage over individual partners, clashed with core WTO principles of reciprocity and nondiscrimination, which prohibit the very practices he sought to pursue (Bown 2022).

In pursuit of his agenda, Trump took steps to undermine the WTO's effectiveness. His administration withheld vital resources, most notably by blocking appointments to the Appellate Body, a move that crippled the WTO's dispute-settlement mechanism.[65] By December 2019, the Appellate Body was rendered inoperative, leaving disputes unresolved because losing parties could effectively stall rulings by appealing "into the void." This tactic undercut the WTO's ability to enforce its rules, enabling member states to flout trade obligations without consequence.[66]

Trump's administration also violated WTO agreements by imposing unilateral tariffs on steel, aluminum, and other goods, targeting both adversaries like China and traditional allies. These actions bypassed the WTO's established dispute-resolution mechanisms, with the administration frequently invoking the nebulous "national security" exemption to justify its measures.[67] Coupled with sharp public criticism, including threats to withdraw from the organization,[68] Trump's rhetoric further eroded confidence in the WTO's impartiality and efficacy (Carnegie and Carson 2019).

The WTO, for its part, responded with a series of strategic countermeasures to mitigate the impact of US hostility. Recognizing the need to sideline Trump's obstructionism,[69] the WTO maintained its core functions, continuing to hear trade disputes, facilitate negotiations, and monitor compliance among the rest of its membership. When the Appellate Body became defunct, the organization worked with other states, notably the European Union, to establish a Multi-Party Interim Appeal Arrangement (MPIA). This innovative workaround allowed willing members to resolve disputes through independent arbitration, bypassing US opposition and preserving the integrity of the dispute-settlement system for participating countries.[70] Recent scholarship suggests that the MPIA has been an effective stopgap, making it a prime example of how institutions can successfully sideline populists (Pelc 2024).